

When The Tree Talked Back

There was nothing particularly special about the trees down in Mulbush, their branches swayed in the wind and their leaves fell off in the winter. Just like any other tree that you'd find anywhere else. But despite all of this there was one tree who stood out just slightly more than all the other trees in the forest, its trunk stood upon the highest hill, its roots extended farther out than all the other trees and its branches bore the most leaves of all the trees in Mulbush (by 63 to be exact, but who's counting). Once, a boy who looked far too young to be wandering in the woods all by himself stumbled upon this tree. The boy climbed the tree's trunk and swung from its branches. This angered the tree greatly. *"Don't you know that I am the mightiest tree in this entire forest? My trunk has found its place on top of the highest hill, my roots grow farther than you could ever imagine and yet here you are climbing up my branches like I am some kind of playground,"* is what the tree would have said to the small boy, but because the tree was nothing more than a tree, it could not talk back so instead it just swayed in the wind as it had done for decades. As the sun began to set and the boy began to get tired of climbing up trees that did not want to be climbed, he made his way back to the ground and took a seat, using the tree as a backrest and he began to ask questions. Now, why the boy would talk to a tree who he knew would never reply, the tree would never know.

"My name's Jonah. Mr. Tree, do you have a name?" That was the first question the boy, Jonah, had asked. The tree would never respond but if he could, he would have said, *"Why would a tree ever need a name? That's like asking if blades of grass have names. Our feats say more about us than a name ever will. I for one am the mightiest tree in all of the forest."* Alas, the tree would never be able to say that so instead it swayed in the wind as it always had and always would. But Jonah didn't seem to mind, he talked enough for the both of them anyway. Soon, the sun had set completely and the only light in the woods came from the luminescence of the moon. The boy was beginning to talk about his best friends, another subject that the tree could not relate to, when a voice in the distance started to call out, "Jonah! Jonah, it's far too late for you to be outside, why don't you come in and eat your supper?"

"Well, Mr. Tree," the boy said as he got off the ground, there was grass stuck onto his backside but what could a tree do about that, "I guess I have to go. I promise I'll come back though," the boy began to run down the hill. And as the boy grew to nothing more than a speck in the distance, the tree wished, for the first time in its life, that his friend would come back.

The next day, as the tree was enjoying the late-spring weather, light clouds with sunlight that sprinkled onto its bountiful leaves, it heard an ever-too-familiar voice.

"Hello, Mr. Tree," if the tree could talk back it would have said to the small boy, *"Hello to you too, Jonah. How are you enjoying the weather today?"* But because the tree and the boy would never be able to have a conversation with each other, the boy started to climb up the tree instead, just as he had done the day before. But instead of getting comfortable on the ground, with his back up against the tree as he had done the day before, when the boy was done playing, he sat down comfortably on one of the tree's branches. Previously, this action would have been outrageous to the tree but today he found the actions comforting, he was glad that his branches, which he was so proud of, could be of use to his friend.

Mr. Tree, the boy started as he laid down between two of the tree's arms, "Do you have a favorite color?" As usual, the tree did not respond but if one day trees did miraculously learn to talk he would say, *"I love all colors, Jonah, I love the reds and the oranges and the greens that are the colors of my leaves, I love all shades of blue as they appear in the sky, from daytime's light blue to midnight's indigo. But if I had to pick a favorite, it would be purple. It doesn't appear often but when it does, it always brings*

something good with it.” Just like the day before, Jonah sat with the tree for hours, asking the tree more and more questions and never failing to fill in the silence when the tree failed to answer. But eventually, as the bright afternoon sky faded into dark indigo and the moon replaced the sun, the boy finally climbed down from his spot in the tree, gathered his things just as he had done the day before, and ran down the hill. Soon, the boy was too far away to see but today the tree wasn't worried about if the boy would ever return because Jonah had left something behind. A little hat hanging just barely off a twig, that just so happened to be the color purple.

As the years went on, Jonah continued to come and talk to the tree. They talked (more like Jonah talked and the tree listened) about leaving home and their first loves, the tree was glad he wasn't able to talk during those two conversations as he knew nothing about such subjects, but they also talked about more trivial matters, like what they would want to be of they in their next lives, Jonah had wanted to be a bird and the tree decided that he would want to be a human so that he could finally respond to all of Jonah's questions. Although sometimes he would leave for months on end, he always came back with more questions and stories to tell. The tree had watched Jonah grow from a small, young rambunctious boy, into a young man whose height almost rivaled the tree's (although the tree on the top of the hill would always remain taller). One day, Jonah had even brought his two kids with him to meet the tree. As Jonah watched his two saplings climb up the tree and swing around, for the first time in all of the years that the tree and the boy had been friends, Jonah looked sad. The man had grown far too old to play on the tree the way he used to but appeared to seem like Jonah could give anything to be able to be up there next to his kids, but the tree didn't mind, as long as Jonah was with him it didn't matter what he boy, who was no longer a boy, was doing. Soon enough, the children had stopped coming to the tree, according to Jonah they had grown too old for playing and had gone off to start their new lives elsewhere. So alas, life went back to Jonah and the tree once again.

One night, when Jonah had grown old and his trips up the hill took longer and longer to complete with each passing day, Jonah went to visit the tree. Now this was peculiar as Jonah had never visited the tree this late before, he always came in the morning and left as soon as the moon hit the sky, he had for years. So the tree figured that Jonah had something especially important to say. But instead of greeting the tree the way he always had, the man sat down on the grass like he had the first time they met and didn't say a word. In fact, he made no sound at all, all the tree could hear was Jonah's loud, raspy breathing that the tree had gotten used to as Jonah aged. The two of them sat like that in the morning, because the winds were particularly quiet that night, the tree didn't even sway.

“Mr. Tree, how would you like it if we could be together the rest of time?” Jonah asked, breaking the silence. Over the years his high pitch, childish voice had matured and become raspy and slow, like he carefully thought about every word before it came out of his mouth. *“Jonah, 104 years of living, you're my only friend, if I could walk, I'd follow you to the end of the Earth, if my roots didn't grow beneath the ground they would have wrapped around years ago as you are the entity keeping me from death. That's how much I would like for us to be together,”* is what the tree would say if trees could speak, but just like pigs will never fly, trees will never talk, so nothing was said. But the tree was fine with that because as always, Jonah would speak enough for the both of them, just as he always had. So the tree waited. Jonah remained silent at the base of the tree. The tree waited some more. *“Jonah? Did you fall asleep?”* The man was as quiet as the tree. The tree continued to wait, he waited until the Sun rose and then because he had nothing to do, the tree waited all of that day. And then when night came the tree waited another night to hear Jonah's voice. Days and nights passed and eventually new people who the tree had never seen

before appeared and took Jonah away from the tree. Somehow, the tree knew that Jonah would never return, their daily conversations had come to an end. But even then, the tree could still feel the weight of Jonah's lanky, elderly body against the tree, as if he was still sitting there. When the tree could finally talk back he would say to the boy, *Jonah, you came back. Just like you always have.*